

**GROUP AFFILIATION, ASSOCIATION, AND DISSOCIATION
IN THE DEBATE BETWEEN NEW YORK SENATORIAL
CANDIDATES HILLARY CLINTON AND RICK LAZIO**

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In seemingly another era, of United States history, before New York and Washington were attacked, non-presidential elections for the United States Senate took place. From the end of the Cold War around 1990 until September 11, 2001, domestic issues such as education and health care, campaign soft money, and taxes, were the main orders of the day. The United States Federal Government was actually taking in more money than it was spending. Even George H. W. Bush's Gulf War seemed far away to many of those living in the United States.

However, economic challenges as well as disparities did persist in part of the United States. Such was the case in the most populous northeastern state, New York. The race to succeed Senator Daniel Patrick Moynihan pitted the sitting First Lady of the United States, Democrat Hillary Rodham Clinton, and her challenger, Republican United States Representative Rick Lazio, a four-term House member from suburban Long Island.

One of the key moments of this Senatorial race took place in a televised debate broadcast from Buffalo on September 13, 2000. Because Clinton was associated closely with a former Arkansas governor and had only recently established a domicile in the State of New York, her challenge was not only to convince New Yorkers to agree with her platform, but also that she belonged as one of those she proposed to represent. In 1964, Robert F. Kennedy, who had hailed from Massachusetts, was a transplanted successful candidate. However, Clinton faced the additional challenge of dissociating herself from scandals in both Washington and Arkansas. Lazio, on the other hand, was not without challenges regarding association and dissociation with at least parts of New York. As a representative

from an affluent district on Long Island, he, too, was viewed as an outsider in parts of the state. Lazio faced the additional challenge of obtaining the belated GOP nomination, after the initial frontrunner, New York City Mayor Rudolph Giuliani, had to withdraw from the race for health reasons.

Group Membership, Association, and Dissociation

Much of the 2000 Senate Race in New York revolved around questions of group membership.

1. Is Hillary Clinton a New Yorker?¹
2. Can Rick Lazio, a Long Islander, really understand the needs of Buffalo and New York City?²
3. How do the tensions between groups defined as New York City, suburban NYC, and Upstate New York and its sub-groupings shape responses to the candidates' argumentative discourse?

¹Cos and Snee (2001) in their study of the Clinton and Lazio campaign stressed the importance of how well the candidates could define themselves as authentic New Yorkers. Going into the debate, for example, Long Island resident Nora Ammarati summed up the concerns of some New Yorkers before the debate when she said, "I think that to be able to deal with the problems of New York, you need to be a resident of New York. I don't think coming here for a couple of months makes you qualified to represent New York in the Senate" (*Newshour*, 2002, para. 9). However, both Cos and Snee (2001) and Anderson (2002) concurred the debate constituted a key point where Clinton turned the "New Yorker" argument to her advantage. Cos and Snee (2001) offer convincing evidence from both voter reaction and subsequent press coverage that by then end of the debate, many voters considered Clinton to be the more authentic New Yorker. Hence, the candidates' performances in this debate both proved key to Clinton's ultimate election night victory.

² In an October 19, 2000, *NewsHour* Report, Kwame Holman noted that "A majority of voters in and around Buffalo are registered among Democrats, but they've felt comfortable helping elect Republicans in recent years. Across the rest of upstate New York, most voters are reliably Republican. Rick Lazio needs to do extremely well in both places in order to offset Hillary Clinton's dominance in heavily-Democratic New York City." (para. 45). In her study, however, Anderson (2002) demonstrated how Clinton blunted this advantage throughout her campaign by making specific reference to her conversations with residents throughout New York, and by shifting the debate from gender to character. Additionally, Anderson notes how the gender issue came to backfire more on Lazio.

4. Inasmuch as a New Yorker can belong to several groups at the same time, how intricate and complex a matter is the notion of belonging to a group in determining the outcome of a debate?

Throughout the debate both candidates struggled with issues of group membership, association and dissociation. This essay applies Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca's (1971) notions of the group and its members, association, and dissociation, to examine why Clinton was able to gain enough of an upper hand in this debate to help turn a slight lead into an eleven percentage point electoral victory for this Senate seat (CNN, 2000). Many of the strategies of association and dissociation in this debate were replayed throughout the remainder of the campaign, suggesting the debate's continued influence. Earlier studies that included this debate (Cos & Snee, 2001; Anderson, 2002) point extensively to the media coverage of the Buffalo debate as shaping the remainder of the campaign. These findings confirm a pattern for 2000 politics, where Banwart, Bystrom, and Robertson (2003) discovered that although media stereotypes persisted, women in male-female races "created more influential news or at least the more influential campaigns", partly explaining why all seven female Senatorial nominees won the general elections that year, as well as three of five nominees for governorships (p. 675). Each study supports the notion that, at least, the performances in the Buffalo debate, within the context of 2000 state politics, constituted a pivotal moment in the way each candidate framed the campaign.

How did Clinton do it, and what proved to be Lazio's ultimate undoing?

Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca define association and dissociation as follows:

By processes of association we understand schemes to bring separate elements together and allow us to establish a unity among them, positively or negatively, by means of one another. By processes of dissociation, we mean techniques of separation which have the purpose of dissociating, separating, disuniting elements which are regarded as forming a whole or at least a unified group within some system of thought: dissociation modifies such a system by modifying certain concepts which make up its essential parts (p. 109).

In this campaign, then, could Clinton and New York be brought together, and could Clinton bring herself together with her issues? Wallace (1989) explains Perelman's concept of dissociation as "the process of breaking the connections between concepts, that is, between the element of one concept and the element of another concept" (p. 111).

In other words, how could Clinton dissociate "first lady" – of either Arkansas or the United States – from the concept "United States Senator from New York"? Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca (1971) add that, "Psychologically and logically, all association implies dissociation, and conversely, the same form which unites various elements into a well-organized whole dissociates them from the neutral background, from that which separates them" (p. 109). So, by establishing what constitutes "New Yorker," "character," or "viable candidate," what dissociations would each candidate make? Writing about Perelman, Maneli (1994) posited that the ultimate aim of the advocate employing strategies such as these was not necessarily to *change* the attitudes of an audience, but rather to gain the *adherence* of an audience. As Maneli (1994) notes, "In order to achieve such an 'adherence' of the public one should take into count not only the general 'spirit' or 'attitude' of the given nation, society, or any other limited audience, but also the complicated, mixed, and even contradictory feelings of the audience" (p. 52). In this case, adherence would mean voting for one candidate over the other, without necessarily agreeing with all of their past positions or behaviors.

Certainly, then, the New York Senate race, as would any race in New York, contain many intricacies. In this pivotal debate, however, three moments do encapsulate how group membership, association, and dissociation operate:

- 1) each candidate's attempt to associate themselves with "New York", and to dissociate their opponent from the state or parts thereof;
- 2) Lazio's attempt to associate Clinton with the alleged misdeeds of her husband, and Clinton's response; and, most notably
- 3) a key moment where Lazio attempted aggressively to get Clinton to sign off on a pledge on a policy as a means of association, but Clinton declining to do so.

The latter moment was not only replayed throughout the remainder of the campaign, but has been cited by rhetorical scholars as a defining point of the campaign (Cos & Snee, 2001; Anderson, 2002). Each candidate was attempting to develop a rhetoric that would invite voters to understand these associations in a way that would result in adherence in the form of a favorable vote.

The Group Identity “New Yorker”

With regards to the entire Clinton and Lazio campaign, Cos and Snee (2001) posit that “This fight turned on a single question: What does it mean to be a New Yorker?” (p. 2027). Looking to capitalize on a number of television ads portraying Clinton as an outsider (Anderson, 2002), Lazio attempted early in the debate to establish himself as the only New Yorker. Lazio’s first statement in the debate, responding to Clinton’s stance on health care, attempted boldly to establish himself as part of a group identity (and to dissociate Clinton from that group) as follows:

You know, a New Yorker would never have made that proposal. In New York you’ve got to tell it like it is. And the way it is is that Mrs. Clinton has had two opportunities—two opportunities to make policy: One on health care and one on education. And on health care it was an unmitigated disaster. Even the people in her own party ran away from it. And worse still, it would have been a disaster for New York. It would have led to health care rationing. It would have destroyed teaching hospitals. It would have led to all types of unintended consequences. But the bottom line would be that it would have been terrible for New York. But it didn’t stop just there. Mrs. Clinton also stood silently by when the president exercised his only line item veto – to hurt Medicaid going to New York. And that’s the true picture of this case (Transcript, 2000, para. 17).

Indeed, the terms “New York” and “New Yorker” appeared frequently throughout his argument. However, sometimes Lazio’s associations tended to dissociate his candidacy from New York, even as he invoked the state’s name. For example, in response to a

question concerning why Erie County had population losses numbering 45,000 over the past 10 years, Lazio said, “. . . we do focus on creating more jobs through Internet access and also by building partnerships with the State of New York, and a \$1,000.00 tax credit for every job created over 20 years for new businesses. And they targeted the upstate economy” (Transcript, 2000, para. 43). Certainly, Lazio is trying to play to an upstate immediate audience by outlining specific strategies. However, as Cos and Snee note (2001) note he does this to his own peril by associating himself with a *geographical* New York with boundaries, constituting an exclusionary rhetoric not conducive to audience adherence.

By contrast, Clinton effectively dissociated Lazio with more than New York, while personalizing her association with the people there:

Well again, I just have to point out that The Buffalo News, which has done a very good series of articles about the problems in the upstate economy, refer to my opponent as orbiting another planet. Because I have now spent countless hours talking to parents who tell me with tears in their eyes that their children had to leave upstate, leave their hometowns because there weren't jobs for them. I want to help address that, not ignore it, not put happy talk on it and I have a plan to do that. (Transcript, 2000, para. 45).

Referring to this exact passage, Cos and Snee (2001) note, “Mrs. Clinton asserted her knowledge of an empathy for the situation while juxtaposing Mr. Lazio’s ‘incorrect’ stance, suggesting a persona of someone who is not in touch with the issues central to that area” (p. 2023). In terms of dissociation, Clinton reinforces a disconnect between Lazio with two major areas of New York State—the city, and the upstate populations. A few moments earlier, Lazio’s referring one of his economic plans as “something I’ve been doing down in Long Island” (Transcript, 2000, para. 39) furnished a context of argument which set the stage for Clinton’s ability to dissociate Lazio with key portions of the state, as well as establish an emotional tie as somebody who can represent large constituencies within New York. Coupled with the notion that Clinton had, on some levels, been living and campaigning in New York before Lazio had joined the race, Lazio’s attempts at association

and dissociation with being New Yorker proved at best a wash in this contest, and in some cases were turned by Clinton's ability to humanize economic and health issues in this debate. As well, Lazio's remarks such as "I don't think we need that Little Rock record in the Big Apple" (Transcript, 2000, para. 53) regarding the vouchers in education debate were either neutralized or backfired as Clinton was able to make similar associations between Lazio and his own Southern political ally, Newt Gingrich of Georgia.

"Mrs." Clinton and Character

Whether intentional, acting according to protocol, or not, the references by the panelists, moderator Tim Russert, and Lazio to the Democratic candidate as "Mrs. Clinton" did reinforce negative gender stereotypes, did reinforce her association with her husband's recent Monica Lewinsky scandal, and did reinforce the fact that she was running mainly on the virtue of being married to the impeached President rather than a real desire to serve New York constituents effectively in the United States Senate. Such references reflected the stereotypical coverage women candidates still faced in 2000 despite some of the advantages many were able to gain via their rhetoric (Banwart, Bystrom, & Robertson, 2003; Anderson, 2002). When asked about her earlier comments about allegations of misconduct against her husband having been a "right wing conspiracy," Clinton attempted to refocus on economic issues. When Russert, however, asked Lazio whether Lazio would stand by a fund-raising letter which claimed that Clinton had embarrassed the nation in her response to the Monica Lewinsky affair, Lazio said:

I stand by that fund-raising letter. I stand by that statement. And I think that, frankly, what's so troubling here with respect to what my opponent just said, is somehow that it only matters what you say when you get caught. And character and trust is about well more than that. And blaming others every time you have responsibility? Unfortunately, that's become a pattern, I think, for my opponent. And it's something that I reject and I believe that New Yorkers reject. We can do well better (Transcript, 2000, para. 76).

Shortly after this exchange, Clinton (perhaps unwittingly reinforcing herself with the president), spoke at length about the substantial federal budget surplus at the time and how that surplus should be used not only to pay down the national debt but also to address problems common to New Yorkers and other U.S. Americans alike. Lazio attempted to make this association negative by responding, “Let me say, it’s beyond shameless, I guess. You know, I guess that the tactic of naming a bunch of things and knowing I don’t have time to answer them is just positively Clintonesque” (para. 91).

Within these exchanges, the inescapable link of “Mrs. Clinton” to “Mr. Clinton” was reinforced. However, Clinton was able to transform negative associations into positive ones by noting the budget accomplishments, thereby blunting Lazio’s issues regarding taxation and budgets. At the same time, she was able to distance herself from the administration by focusing more on issues. As Clinton reinforced her association with issues, any attempts Lazio made to tie Clinton to corruption in the Bill Clinton administration faded. In some cases, though, the association of Clinton to the administration was turned into an advantage with Clinton’s arguments such as “I will use my 30 years of experience, my last eight years in the White House to bring to bear not just the votes that I cast or the speeches I make on the floor of the Senate. I’ll be using everything at my disposal to try to be an effective partner, to help create job and turn the economy around upstate” (Transcript, 2000, para. 32), “I’ve been a steady, consistent voice on behalf of children and families and what I’ve worked for for 30 years. And I want to try to put that experience to work for the people of New York” (Transcript, 2000, para. 71), and “I’ve known him [Joe Lieberman] for 30 years” (Transcript, 2000, para. 74). In other words, rather than an association with corruption, the association Lazio tried to make between Mr. and Mrs. Clinton tended to backfire in this particular debate, coming across as a personal attack against a backdrop of analysis and direct issue-specific argumentation by the Democratic candidate.

One reason why Lazio’s dissociation strategies backfire would be Clinton’s *very presence* in this debate. This presence, reinforced by her straightforward responses

regarding the issues, made it difficult for Lazio to attack character while in her presence. As well, Lazio's choice to attack character shifted his central strategy of dissociating Clinton from the group New Yorkers. On the other hand, Clinton at this juncture was able to reinforce the association between herself and her ideas with either New York or parts of New York, with the context of having engaged in a year-long "listening tour" reinforcing her association with issues affecting the people of New York.

Sign it Right Now!

Within the context of having at least neutralized the notion of which candidate better relates to New York and having distanced herself from that which was allegedly corrupt in the Bill Clinton administration (but associating with its budgetary successes), Clinton's repeated association with experience was reinforced with the following exchange regarding soft money funding attack ads and mailings toward the end of the debate, before the closing statements (Transcript, 2000):

Clinton: . . . If you will get signed agreements from all your friends who say they're

Raising \$32 million and will not be running so-called independent ads, will not be doing push-polling, will not be doing mass mailings that are filled with these outrageous personal attacks, I think we can have an agreement. I'd like to see these signed letters from all those different groups that you counted on to flood this state.

You know I was in Tonawanda not long ago and I was at the senior center at a lunch and an elderly woman, you know, reached up to shake my hand. She said, I'm glad to see you in person because I've been getting the meanest mail about you. Well, I know that everybody in New York is getting flooded with mean mail.

I think if we can sign agreements from all of your allies- when you wouldn't ask the one group to stop – but if you will get those signed agreements, then, you know, we can make a deal. But I also –

Russert: Do we have a deal, Mr. Lazio?

Lazio: Who said – I – I'd like to get it done today.

Russert: Will you get those signed agreements?

Lazio: Yeah, I'd be happy to. But I want you to be the – I want to get it done right now.

I don't want any more wriggle room. I don't want any more evasion. The truth is, Tim, is that Mrs. Clinton has been airing millions of dollars in soft-money ads. It's the height of hypocrisy to talk about soft money when she's been raising soft money by the bucket loads out in Hollywood and spending all that money on negative advertising. Height of hypocrisy. Let's just get this deal done right now.

Russert: Can I give Mrs. Clinton?

Lazio: Right here, here it is. Let's sign it. It's – it's the New York Freedom of Soft Money Pact. I signed it. We can – we can both sit down together. We can get all the media in here. We will make sure it's an ironclad deal. And – and I'm – I'm happy to – to abide by anything that we all agree on. But let's get it done now. Let's not get any more wriggle room.

Russert: Mrs. Clinton, do you want to respond?

Clinton: Well, yes, I certainly do. You know, I - I - I- I admire that. That was wonderful performance and I –

Lazio: Well, why don't you just sign it?

Clinton: And you – and you did it very well.

Lazio: I'm not asking you to admire it. I'm asking you to sign it.

Clinton: Well, I would be happy when you give me the signed letters –

Lazio: Well, right here. Right here.

Clinton: When you give me –

Lazio: Right here, sign it right now.

Clinton: Well – well, we'll shake. We'll shake on this –

Lazio: No, no. I want your signature. Because I think that everybody wants to see you Signing something that you said you were for. I'm for it. I haven't done it. You've been violating it. Why don't you stand up and do something – do something

important for America? While America is looking at New York, why don't you show some leadership because it goes to trust and character?

Clinton: And - and this new radio ad from the Republican Party using soft money is not part of your campaign.

Lazio: Oh, well what are we talking about here? No, let's put things in perspective.

Russert: We – we are – we are out of time. We have to go out. (Transcript, 2000, para. 146-168).

In this exchange, in a memorable image, Lazio approached Clinton with a piece of paper, and was rather aggressive in body language as well as words while insisting that Clinton sign the paper. This particular exchange was intended to make a dramatic point of Clinton's out of state fundraising as well as to dissociate her from the voters through association with Hollywood. However, both Lazio's running out of time, and Clinton's ability to associate her opponent with soft money ads from the central GOP, tended to neutralize these associations. In fact, the exchange not only reinforced prior media images of Lazio appearing inexperienced, but also "unhinged."

Association, Dissociation, and the Clinton Victory

Although Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca's notions regarding argumentation surrounding group membership, association, and dissociation contribute to an explanation of Clinton's gaining an upper hand in this debate and maintaining an advantage that culminated in election night victory, some ambiguity exists as to how much these issues contributed to ultimate victory. Just as the debate ran out of time, the author runs out of space in a Forum section. But it can be summed up this way: When it comes to strategies of group identity, association, and dissociation, as Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca (1971) note:

Argumentation concerning a group in its members is far more complex than that concerning a person and his [sic] acts, in the first place, because a person always belongs to a number of different groups, but mainly because the notion of group is

vaguer than the notion of person. There may be doubt not only as to the limits of the group, but as to its very existence (p. 322).

In the case of the present analysis, further study might address how intersections between other groups (such as union members, party members, families, suburbanites, ethnic divisions within the various regions in New York) might nuance how a statewide race will pay out. More importantly for this analysis, we might ask, what constitutes a New Yorker, or, for that matter, what constitutes a Californian, a Texan, or even a North Carolinian (apparently not an insurmountable problem for Elizabeth Dole, who, like Clinton, was able to win a Senate seat despite – or perhaps because of – her association with a Senator from Kansas who once won a party nomination from U.S. President)? As the United States changes dramatically in an age of information and easy travel, the groups that constitute the nation and their identities differ radically from even a decade ago. Hence, the notion of groups was we have understood them as being ephemeral, vague, or undefined rings true. As well, the outcome of the strategies to associate or dissociate among groups may fall flat, or backfire, as Rick Lazio discovered in his 2000 bid for United States Senate.

Additionally, Lazio's attacks on Clinton's character or honestly may have further drawn attention from the not only the notion of his being a geographical New Yorker (a strategy that would not help even if he did succeed, as Cos and Snee [2001] noted), but as a person who truly sees New York as a destiny, or who knows New York. Referring to Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca, Schiappa (2003) has noted that "definitions are dominant (for example, canonized in a dictionary) only as most people continue to adhere to them" (p. 31). Gross and Dearin (2003) concur. In this case, whether Clinton, in fact, was of good character, became irrelevant in a debate where the key issue became to define oneself as a "New Yorker." By campaigning consistently both in advertising and then in the debate that Clinton was of poor character, then, Lazio undermined his own strategy of emphasizing that he was the only New Yorker in the debate. By contrast, Clinton's capitalizing on her experiences during her extended listening campaign – a campaign begun with President Clinton in a supporting role, not speaking at the announcement – contributed to audience

adherence based on New York not merely as a place, but as a state of mind (Cos and Snee, 2001). Associating all of the parts of New York into this state of mind went a long way in explaining not only Clinton's victory in the debate, but in the race as well.

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